‘demand for giving the OBCs Commission constitutional status was on for many years.’

Congress governments used to come, make promises at time of elections, click pictures with OBC leaders and forget about it after elections got over. Congress used to keep it hanging, so in each election, this issue could be revived. This was their politics of selfishness. But BJP gave this commission constitutional status to solve the problem of backwards classes–OBCs so that backward classes get justice. You must have seen that people were spreading lies that Modi will come, BJP will come and remove reservation. Recently in Parliament we took a decision to increase SC–ST reservation for ten years. This is the result of BJP’s national policies.[45]

Finally, and importantly, even as the BJP homed in on the OBC narrative, the party did not lose its focus on the general category (or upper castes) either. So, in January 2019, the Modi government, through another constitutional amendment bill, legislatively also enabled 10 per cent reservation for economically weaker sections (EWS, i.e., the poor among the non-reserved, general category castes).[46] As Modi also emphasised in Dhanbad, ‘Every family has been demanding reservation for the poor in the general category. Every poor person in general category was demanding this for years, running a campaign, but Congress kept postponing legitimate demands, burying them, keeping them hanging. This was the result of the selfish policies of Congress and its associates. BJP, in the interest of the poor, gave 10 per cent reservation to the poor from the general category also. This is our national policy.’[47] In his public outreach, Modi often stresses that the Ministry of Tribal Affairs was carved out as a separate ministry under Atal Bihari Vajpayee in 1999 and that his own government increased funding for the welfare of SCs and STs from ₹66,159 crore in 2013-14 to ₹1.26 lakh crore in 2019-20.[48]

The BJP’s Last-mile Sangathan Re-engineering